360° Marketing Strategy

UPFRONT Protein Bar



Fontys University of Applied Sciences
Marketing Management – Digital Business Concepts

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Abstract

This report presents a 360° marketing strategy for Upfront Protein Bars, a Dutch fast-moving consumer good within the functional snack segment. The research follows the SOSTAC® framework and addresses the three core planning phases: Situation, Objectives, and Strategy.

Chapter 1 analyses the current market situation of Upfront, covering a product description, target group analysis (primary: students aged 18–25; secondary: young professionals aged 25–30), a DESTEP macro-environmental analysis, the current marketing mix (4Ps + People), and an inspiration portfolio of 40 online and offline marketing materials. Three Unique Selling Points clean-label transparency, mainstream lifestyle positioning, and balanced price–quality ratio are formulated and supported by academic sources.

Chapter 2 benchmarks five key competitors (Barebells, Fulfil, Grenade, Eat Natural, and the Albert Heijn private label), enriches the USPs and UBRs based on competitive insights, establishes a SMART goal of increasing online sales by 20% within six months, and maps the customer journey using the AIDA model with quantified funnel estimates.

Chapter 3 reframes the 4Ps into the customer-centric SIVA model, identifies three market opportunities and three threats supported by APA sources, and proposes a cross-media plan integrating TikTok, Instagram, university activations, and gym partnerships. A budget of €6,500 is projected to generate €15,000 - €30,000 in revenue, yielding a positive return on marketing investment. The strategy prioritises a phased approach awareness, engagement, and conversion designed to strengthen Upfront's brand visibility and market share among Dutch students and active young consumers.

Budget estimates are based on the following benchmarks: TikTok ad CPM in the Netherlands averages approximately €5–€10 per thousand impressions, yielding an estimated reach of 200,000–400,000 for a €2,000 spend (Meta/TikTok Business, 2024). Instagram CPM is comparable at €6–€12 (Meta Business, 2024). Outdoor poster placement (abri format) in Dutch cities costs approximately €400–€800 per location per two-week period (JCDecaux NL, 2024). University activation costs (sampling materials, logistics) are estimated at €600–€1,200 based on comparable FMCG campaign benchmarks (NielsenIQ, 2023). Gym partnership placement costs reflect basic vending or display agreements estimated at €400–€800 per location.

1.1 Introduction

This research report focuses on the development of a 360º marketing strategy for **Upfront Protein Bars**, a Dutch fast-moving consumer good within the functional snack segment. The product operates in the broader health and wellness food market, which has shown increasing relevance in the Netherlands due to growing consumer awareness of nutrition and lifestyle choices (RVIM, 2023).

Upfront Protein Bars are sold both online and in physical supermarkets such as Albert Heijn, allowing for the analysis of both offline shelf positioning and online marketing activities. The product was selected because it meets the formal project requirements: it is a B2C product, not a private label, and part of the FMCG sector, meaning it is regularly replaced and purchased.

Furthermore, protein consumption has expanded beyond professional athletes and is increasingly integrated into everyday consumption patterns of young adults (Euromonitor International, 2025). This creates opportunities for strategic repositioning within a clearly defined niche segment, such as students and young professionals.

1.2 Product Description

Name and Type of Product

The selected product category is **Upfront Protein Bars** (all bar flavours). The product belongs to the fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) food category and is positioned within the functional snack segment.

FMCG products are characterized by frequent repurchase, relatively low unit cost, and high distribution intensity (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Specifications

Upfront Protein Bars are individually packaged snack bars of approximately 50–60 grams. Key product characteristics include:

- High protein content compared to conventional snack bars
- Clear front-of-pack ingredient communication
- Shelf-stable packaging
- Multiple flavour variants within the protein bar category

Clear ingredient communication aligns with increased consumer demand for transparency in food labelling (RVIM, 2023) .

Functionality

The product serves as a convenient source of protein for consumers seeking quick nutritional solutions during busy daily routines. It requires no preparation and is suitable for on-the-go consumption.

Typical usage moments include:

- Between lectures
- During study sessions
- Before or after sports activities
- During work or extended screen time

Convenience and portability are key characteristics of modern snack consumption patterns (Euromonitor International, 2025).

Benefits

Upfront Protein Bars offer both functional and psychological benefits:

- Convenient and portable nutrition
- Higher protein intake
- Transparent ingredient communication
- Lifestyle alignment with health-conscious consumers

The increasing societal focus on healthier eating patterns strengthens the perceived value of protein-based snacks (RVIM, 2023).

1.2a Target Group Description

Current Users

Protein bars are commonly consumed by individuals who seek convenient snack options with perceived nutritional benefits, particularly products with higher protein content compared to traditional snacks. Within the Dutch market, this category is often associated with consumers who are interested in health-oriented food choices or functional snacks that can be consumed quickly during everyday activities.

In the Netherlands, young adults represent a substantial consumer segment. According to **Statistics Netherlands**, there are approximately **1.6 million people aged between 18 and 25**, and around **570,000 students enrolled in higher education** (CBS(1), 2024) (CBS(2), 2024). These demographic groups frequently combine studying, work, and social activities, which can increase demand for convenient food products that are easy to consume between activities.

In addition, research on Dutch eating behaviour indicates that **snacking is very common in the Netherlands**, and younger consumers are an important group when discussing snack choices and healthier snack alternatives (Voedingscentrum, 2023). Protein bars are often positioned as functional snacks that combine convenience with perceived nutritional benefits, which may explain their relevance within this broader consumer segment.

Demographic Characteristics

The primary demographic characteristics of the target group are individuals aged **18–30**, including MBO, HBO, and WO students as well as young professionals in the early

stages of their careers. This group typically has a **low to middle income level** and is commonly located in **urban and semi-urban areas**, where universities and workplaces are concentrated.

According to **Statistics Netherlands** (CBS(1), 2024) the Netherlands has approximately **1.6 million people aged between 18 and 25**, and around **570,000 students enrolled in higher education** (CBS(2), 2024).When including vocational education students and young professionals within the broader **18–30 age segment**, the potential target group represents a significant share of the Dutch consumer population. This indicates that the segment is large enough to support a specialized snack product positioned around convenience and functional nutrition.

Psychographic Characteristics

Psychographically, the target group can be characterized as:

- Health-aware but not extreme athletes
- Influenced by lifestyle and social media trends
- Interested in productivity and self-improvement
- Seeking convenient nutrition solutions

Social trends show increasing attention toward protein intake and balanced lifestyles among younger generations (RVIM, 2023).

Buying Behaviour

The buying behaviour of this group is characterized by:

- Supermarket-oriented purchasing
- Sensitivity to price–quality ratio
- Willingness to experiment with flavours
- Influence of packaging and brand transparency

Young consumers increasingly combine rational evaluation (nutritional value) with emotional decision-making (brand identity) when purchasing food products (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Primary Target Group

The primary target group is:

Students aged 18–25 with busy academic lifestyles who seek convenient, protein-rich snacks to support energy and daily performance.

Secondary Target Group

The secondary target group consists of young professionals aged **25–30** who value practical and healthier snack alternatives during working days. This group often has busy schedules and seeks convenient food options that can provide energy during work or commuting.

In addition to this segment, **fitness-oriented consumers such as athletes and gym enthusiasts also remain an important part of the protein bar market**. Protein snacks are commonly associated with sports nutrition and are frequently used by individuals who want to increase their protein intake after workouts or during training routines (International Food Information Council, 2023).

However, because many established protein bar brands already focus heavily on the fitness segment, the marketing strategy for Upfront may benefit from emphasizing a broader lifestyle-oriented positioning that also appeals to students and young professionals who seek convenient and healthier snack options in everyday situations.

1.2b Market Description (DESTEP Analysis)

To analyse the external environment influencing Upfront Protein Bars, a DESTEP analysis is applied. The macro-environment significantly affects FMCG demand and competitive positioning (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Demographic

The Netherlands has a substantial population of young adults enrolled in education and early career stages (CBS(1), 2024) (CBS(2), 2024). Urban concentration of students increases exposure to new brands and retail channels.

Economic

Although students generally have limited disposable income, research shows that consumers are willing to pay a premium for products perceived as healthier

(Euromonitor International, 2025). Rising food prices increase sensitivity to value positioning (CBS(3), 2024).

Social

Health awareness and protein consumption trends are increasing in Dutch society (RVIM, 2023). Social media plays an important role in shaping food preferences among young adults.

Technological

Digital channels influence awareness and purchasing behavior. Online supermarket platforms and social media advertising contribute to brand discovery (Euromonitor International, 2025).

Environmental

Sustainability and ingredient transparency have become increasingly relevant for Dutch consumers (RVIM, 2023). Packaging and sourcing practices influence brand perception.

Political / Legal

Food products in the Netherlands must comply with EU Regulation (EU) No 1169/2011 concerning food information to consumers (European Parliament & Council, 2011). This affects labelling and marketing claims related to protein and health benefits.

Competitor Overview

Key competitors in the Dutch protein bar segment include:

- Barebells
- Quest
- Fulfil
- Eat Natural
- Supermarket private-label protein bars

These competitors compete on protein content, taste, branding, and price positioning.

1.3 Current Marketing Mix (4Ps + 1 Additional P)

The marketing mix (4Ps) provides a structured framework to analyse the current positioning and market approach of Upfront Protein Bars (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022). In addition to the traditional 4Ps, one additional relevant P will be included to enrich the analysis.

Product

Upfront Protein Bars are positioned as high-protein, transparent, and accessible functional snacks. The product category includes multiple flavour variants within the protein bar segment.

Current Product Characteristics:

- High protein content compared to conventional snack bars
- Clear ingredient communication on packaging
- Modern, minimalistic packaging design
- Shelf-stable, individually wrapped format

From a differentiation perspective, the brand emphasizes transparency and simplicity rather than extreme sports positioning. This aligns with growing consumer demand for ingredient clarity and health-conscious snacking (RVIM, 2023).

Compared to competitors such as Barebells and Quest, Upfront appears less performance-focused and more lifestyle-oriented.

Price

Upfront Protein Bars are positioned within the mid-range price segment of supermarket protein bars. They are typically priced above conventional candy bars but competitively within the protein snack category.

Students and young adults are relatively price-sensitive but willing to pay a premium for perceived health benefits (CBS(3), 2024).

Current Pricing Strategy:

- Mid-range pricing
- Comparable to main branded competitors

- Positioned above private-label alternatives

This suggests a **value-based pricing strategy**, where price reflects perceived nutritional and lifestyle benefits (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Place (Distribution)

Upfront Protein Bars are distributed through:

- Large supermarket chains (e.g., Albert Heijn)
- Online supermarket platforms
- Possibly selected online brand channels
- Upfront Foodstore

The product benefits from **intensive distribution**, typical for FMCG products (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022). Being present in mainstream supermarkets increases accessibility and impulse purchase opportunities.

However, shelf placement competes directly with both:

- Premium protein brands
- Private-label protein alternatives

This creates a highly competitive in-store environment.

Promotion

Upfront primarily relies on:

- Social media marketing
- Influencer collaborations
- Brand storytelling focused on transparency
- Online visibility

The communication tone is modern, informal, and lifestyle-oriented. Compared to larger competitors, promotional intensity appears moderate rather than aggressive.

Social media plays a significant role in influencing younger consumers' food choices (Euromonitor International, 2025). However, in-store promotion appears limited, suggesting potential for stronger integration between online and offline campaigns.

Additional P: People (Most Relevant Additional P)

For FMCG brands targeting young consumers, **People** is a highly relevant additional P.

This includes:

- Brand ambassadors
- Influencers
- Community engagement
- Social media interaction

Upfront's communication style suggests a focus on relatability and authenticity rather than elite athlete endorsement.

This observation is based on the analysis of Upfront's brand communication on its official website and social media platforms. The brand primarily uses lifestyle-oriented visuals, informal language, and product-focused messaging rather than professional athlete endorsements or performance-driven imagery. Compared to competitors such as Grenade or Barebells, which frequently highlight gym culture and athletic performance, Upfront's communication style appears more focused on relatability and everyday consumers (Upfront, 2026) (Barebells, 2026) (Grenade, 2026).

Consumer trust is strongly influenced by perceived authenticity and brand transparency (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022). Therefore, the People element plays a strategic role in reinforcing brand identity among students and young adults.

Interim Conclusion of Current Marketing Mix

Upfront Protein Bars currently operate with:

- A transparent, lifestyle-oriented product positioning
- Mid-range pricing
- Intensive supermarket distribution
- Social media–driven promotion
- Strong emphasis on authenticity

However, there appears to be room for:

- Stronger in-store activation
- Clearer niche targeting (e.g., students specifically)

- More integrated 360º communication

This baseline analysis will serve as input for the strategic improvements in later chapters.

1.4 Unique Selling Points (USPs) and Unique Buying Reasons (UBRs)

In order to develop an effective 360º marketing strategy, it is essential to identify the product's Unique Selling Points (USPs) and Unique Buying Reasons (UBRs). A USP reflects the company's perspective: the distinctive feature that differentiates the product from competitors. A UBR, in contrast, reflects the consumer's perspective: the underlying reason why a customer chooses to purchase the product. These two concepts are related but not identical. While USPs are often rational or product-oriented, UBRs are frequently emotional or practical motivations (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

The following USPs and UBRs are derived from competitor comparison, market analysis (Section 1.2b), and academic research on consumer behaviour and food trends.

USP 1: Clean-Label Transparency in a Processed Food Category

The protein bar category is generally perceived as a highly processed food segment. Research shows that consumers increasingly demand "clean-label" products with recognizable ingredients and transparent communication (Asioli, D., Aschemann-Witzel, J., Caputo, V., Vecchio, R., Annunziata, A., Næs, T., & Varela, P., 2017). In the Netherlands, growing awareness regarding nutrition and ingredient transparency has been observed (RVIM, 2023).

Many competing protein bar brands focus primarily on macro-nutrient claims such as "20g protein" or "low sugar," often combined with performance-oriented messaging. Upfront, however, appears to emphasize simplified ingredient communication and accessible transparency as a core element of its brand positioning.

This clean-label orientation differentiates the brand within a category where consumer skepticism toward processed foods is increasing. Transparency reduces perceived risk and strengthens trust, which is particularly relevant in health-related food purchases.

UBR 1: “This Feels Like a Safer and More Honest Choice.”

From the consumer’s perspective, the technical aspect of transparency translates into trust. Students and young adults may not analyse nutritional values in depth, but clear ingredient communication reduces uncertainty and cognitive effort in decision-making. According to clean-label research, transparency increases consumer confidence and purchase intention (Asioli, D., Aschemann-Witzel, J., Caputo, V., Vecchio, R., Annunziata, A., Næs, T., & Varela, P., 2017).

The emotional buying reason therefore becomes the perception of safety and honesty: the product “feels” more reliable compared to competitors.

USP 2: Mainstream Functional Protein Positioning

Protein consumption has expanded beyond professional athletes into mainstream daily consumption patterns. Research indicates that consumers increasingly associate protein with general health, satiety, and lifestyle improvement rather than exclusively muscle building (Bogue & Troy, 2016) (IFIC, 2023).

While several competitors in the protein bar market strongly emphasize athletic performance and gym culture, Upfront appears positioned as an everyday functional snack. The brand communication is less performance-driven and more lifestyle-oriented, making the product accessible to a broader target group.

This positioning reduces identity barriers and broadens market appeal, especially among students who do not necessarily identify as athletes.

UBR 2: “This Fits My Everyday Lifestyle.”

Consumers prefer brands that align with their self-image (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022). Students who do not identify with extreme fitness culture may avoid highly performance-focused brands. Upfront’s more accessible and lifestyle-based positioning reduces identity friction.

The unique buying reason becomes the perception that the product fits seamlessly into daily life without requiring a strong athletic identity.

USP 3: Balanced Price–Quality Positioning in a Price-Sensitive Segment

Economic conditions in the Netherlands show increased food price sensitivity due to inflation (CBS(3), 2024). Students, in particular, represent a price-conscious consumer group. At the same time, research indicates that consumers are willing to pay a moderate premium for products perceived as healthier or functional (Euromonitor International, 2025).

Within the protein bar market, a price hierarchy exists between low-cost private-label products and premium performance brands. Upfront appears positioned within the mid-range segment, offering perceived health benefits without premium pricing.

This balanced positioning allows the brand to remain accessible while maintaining credibility.

UBR 3: "It's a Smart Compromise."

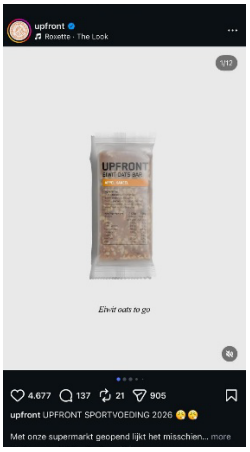
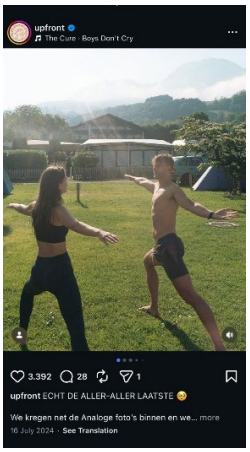
From the consumer perspective, purchase decisions in FMCG categories often involve quick value assessments (Kahneman, 2011). Students evaluate whether a product is worth the price relative to perceived benefits.

The buying reason therefore becomes the perception of making a smart and rational choice: healthier than traditional candy, but not excessively expensive. This perceived value-for-money increases purchase justification and repeat behaviour.

1.5.1 Online Marketing Portfolio

The following categories of online marketing materials were identified:

1. Instagram Posts (Brand Account)

<table>
<tr>
<td>Product visuals
 
</td>
<td>Lifestyle imagery
 
</td>
</tr>
<tr>
<td>Informal tone
 
</td>
<td>Focus on transparency and flavour
 
</td>
</tr>
</table>

2. Instagram Reels / Short-form Video

- Quick product highlights

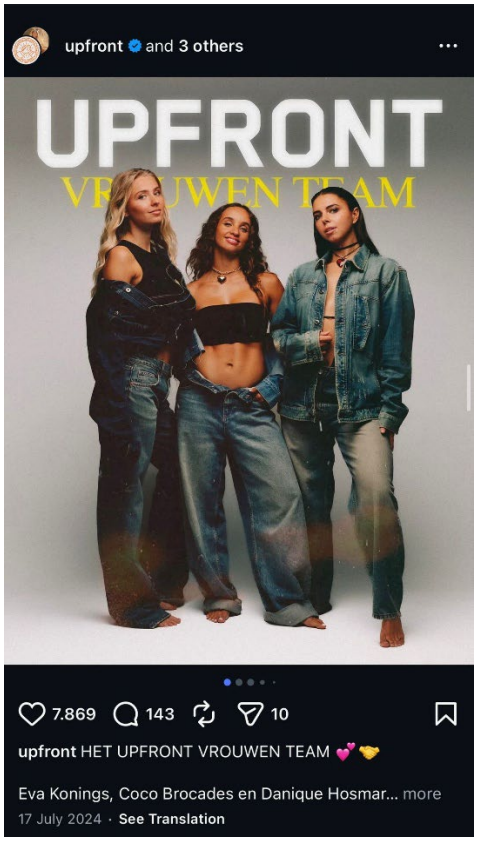
  https://www.instagram.com/reel/DKH8wN9IGYL/?igsh=MTZqODk1eWJ6eG43aQ==

- Engagement-based content

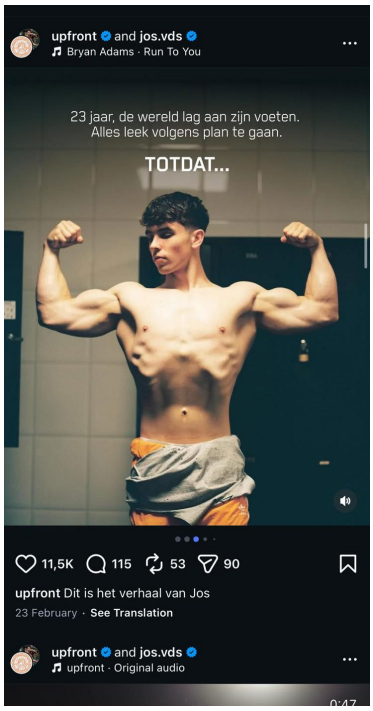
  https://www.instagram.com/reel/DTIBqr1jW8a/?igsh=NWxqcnAwOHlkeHR4

3. Influencer Collaborations

- Lifestyle influencers



- Gym-related micro-influencers



4. Website Product Pages

- Ingredient listing



De originele Upfront Eiwitreep volgens het vertrouwde recept!

- Begrijpbare ingrediënten.
- 15g eiwit per reep.
- Vullend tussendoortje.

Actie!

Vanwege vernieuwing in ons repenassortiment in maart, bieden we deze repen aan met korting.

Allergenen en waarschuwingen

Bevat ei en amandelen. Kan gluten, soja, melk, pinda, pistache, cashew, macadamia, paranoot, hazelnoot en pecannoot bevatten. Niet geschikt voor mensen met een zonnebloempit-allergie.

- Nutritional breakdown

Rijstsiroop
Havervlokken
Cacaoboter
Cichoreiwortelvezel
Witte choco stukjes (cacaoboter, suiker, havermelkpoeder) (2.0%)
Zeezout
Rijstzetmeel

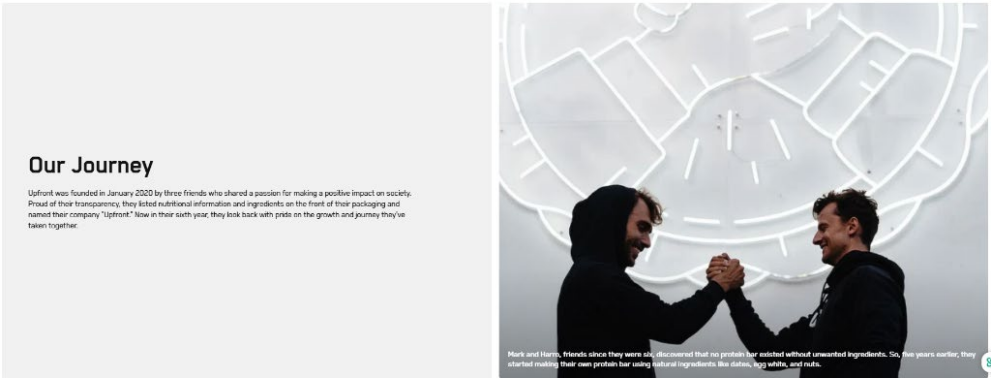


Melkeiwit (19%)
Collageen peptiden
Agavesiroop
Roompoeder (melk)
Gevriesdroogde framboos (1.3%)
Natuurlijk aroma

De Upfront Eiwitcrisp is een heerlijke, knapperige reep met een basis van haver en collageen. Perfect voor onderweg, als tussendoortje of na je training.

- Basis van havermout en collageen.
- Crunchy door eiwitcrisps.
- 15g eiwit per reep.

- Brand storytelling



5. Website Storytelling Section

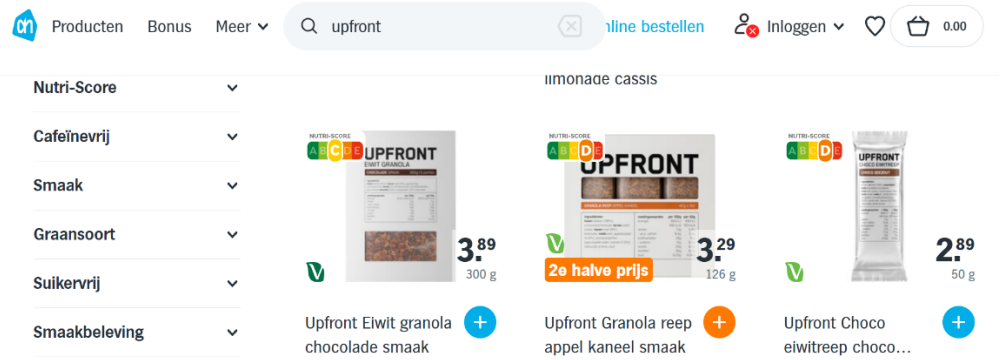
- Company mission





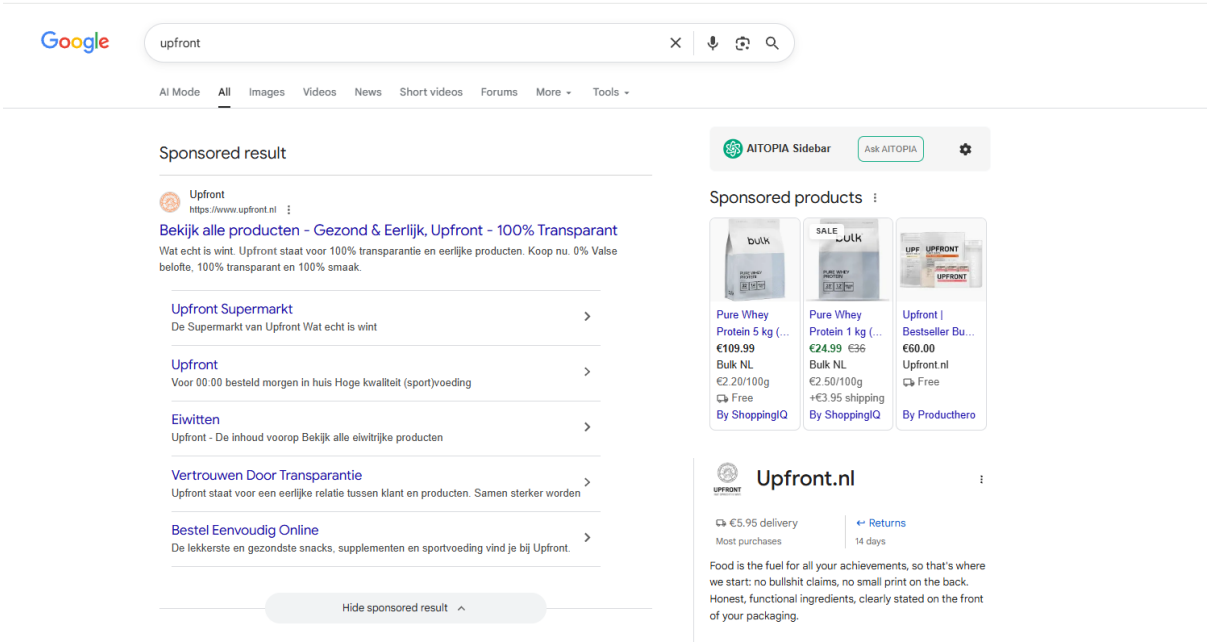
6. Online Supermarket Product Pages (Albert Heijn)

- Product description
- Price positioning
- Neutri-Score



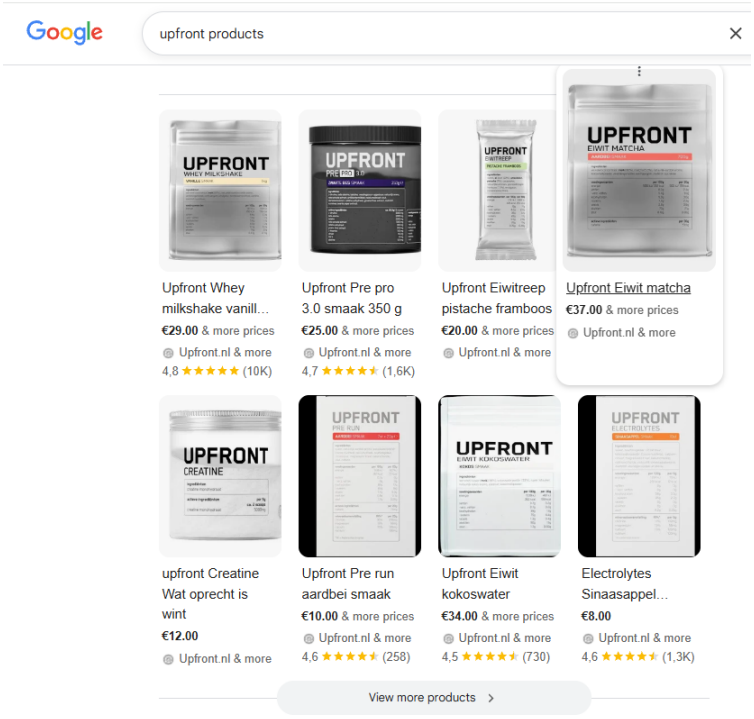
7. Google Search Results (SEO)

- Organic ranking visibility

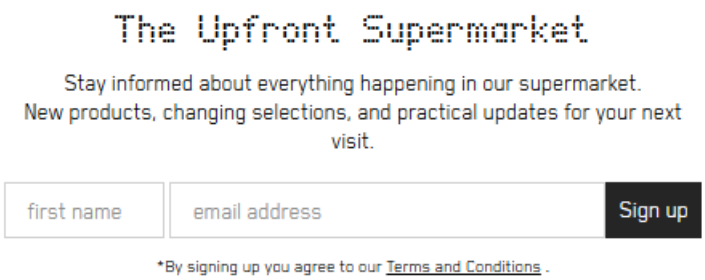


8. Google Ads

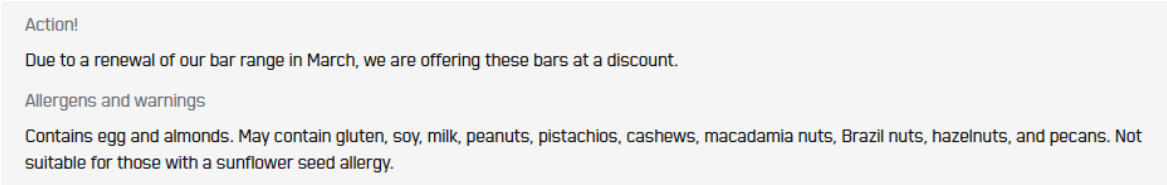
- Sponsored product results



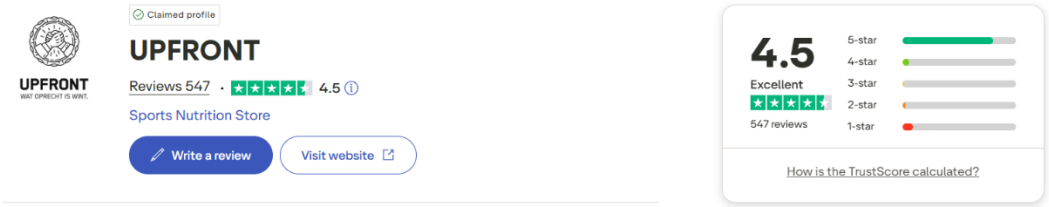
9. Email Marketing (Newsletter sign-up incentive)



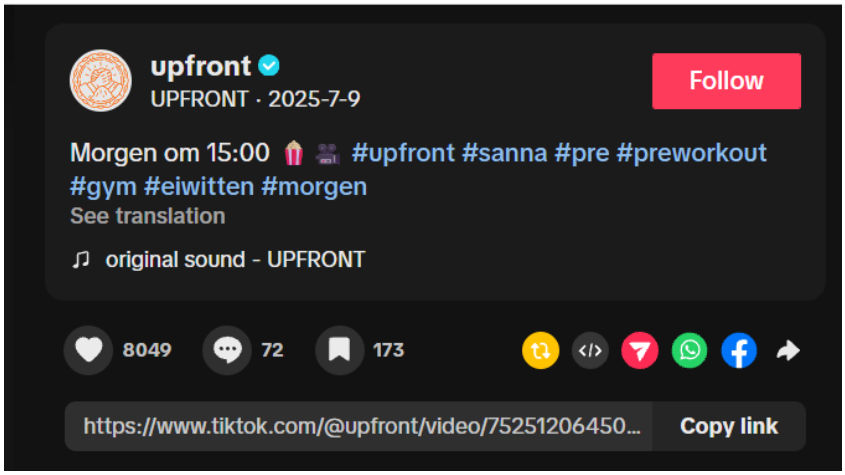
10. Online Discount Campaigns



11. Trustpilot Reviews



12. TikTok Mentions



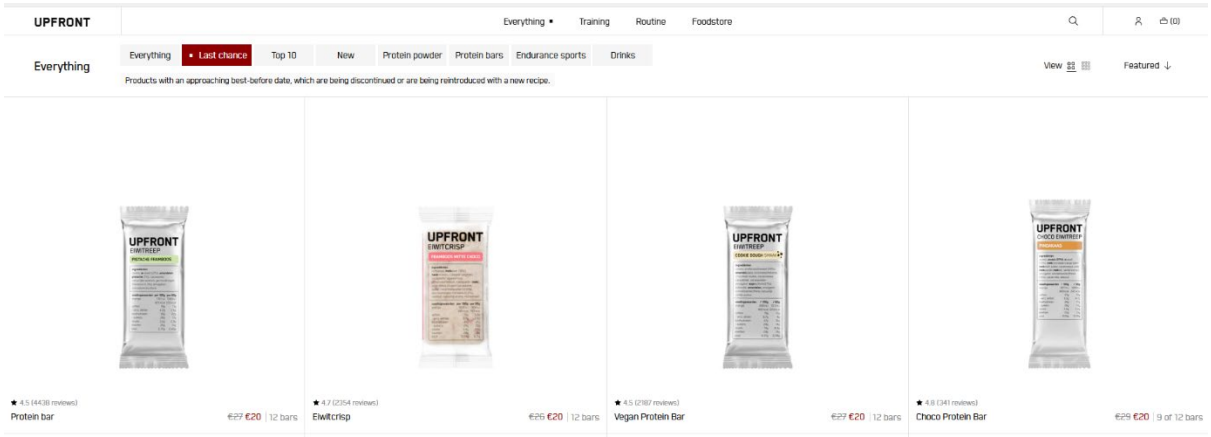
13. Paid Social Ads

https://www.tiktok.com/@upfront/video/7475387138679278870

14. Black Friday Promotions

https://www.tiktok.com/@upfront/video/7302773469547072800

15. Limited-Time Discounts



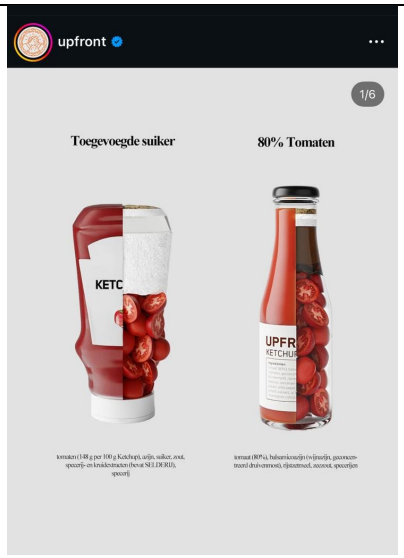
16. Giveaway Campaigns

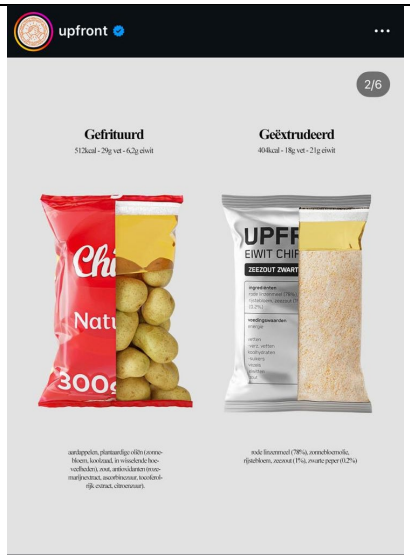
https://www.tiktok.com/@djonivanhilten/video/7588491006715170081

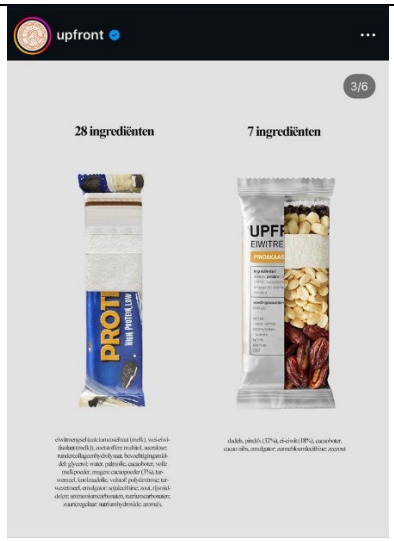
17. Polls or Interactive Stories

18. User-Generated Content Reposts

19. Product Comparison Posts









20. Sponsored Content on Retail Platforms

1.5.2 Offline Marketing Portfolio

Offline examples were collected through store visits (Albert Heijn) and public observation.

1. Shelf Placement in Protein Section



2. Price Tags / Discount Labels

https://www.tiktok.com/@maurits.verweij/video/7519076406966504726

3. Upfront Newspaper



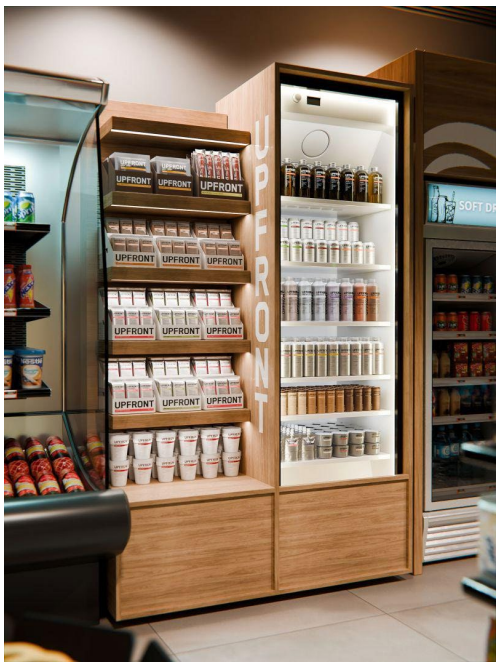


4. In-Store Display Stand





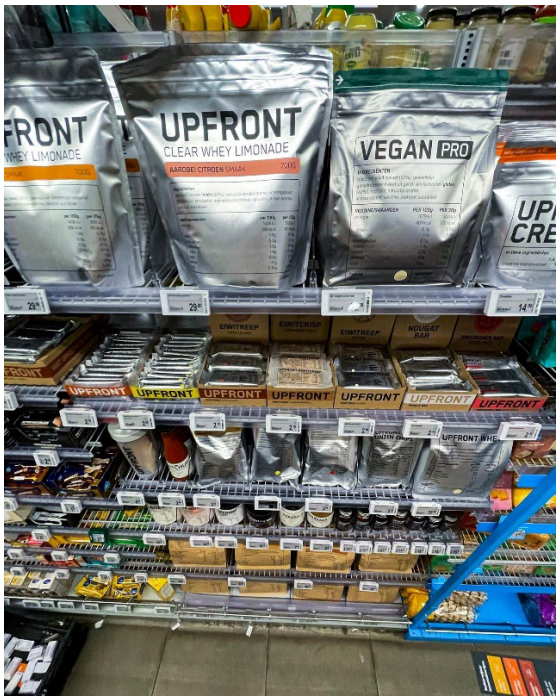
5. Special refrigerator



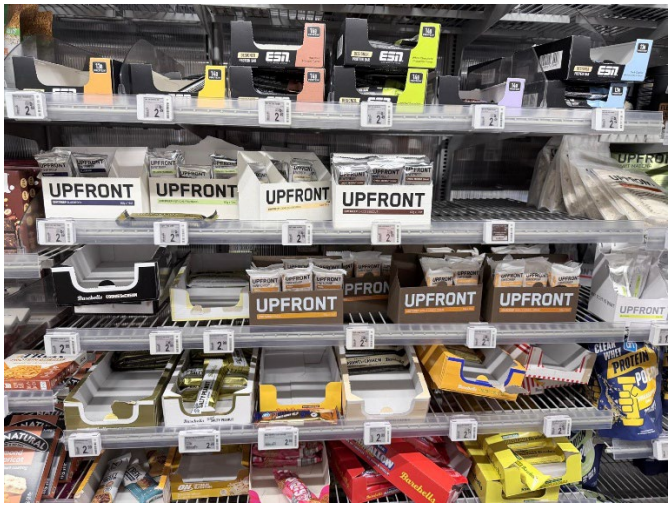
6. Bundle Promotion (Multi-pack discount)



7. Shelf Height Positioning



8. Comparative Proximity to Competitors



9. Promotional Leaflet Inclusion



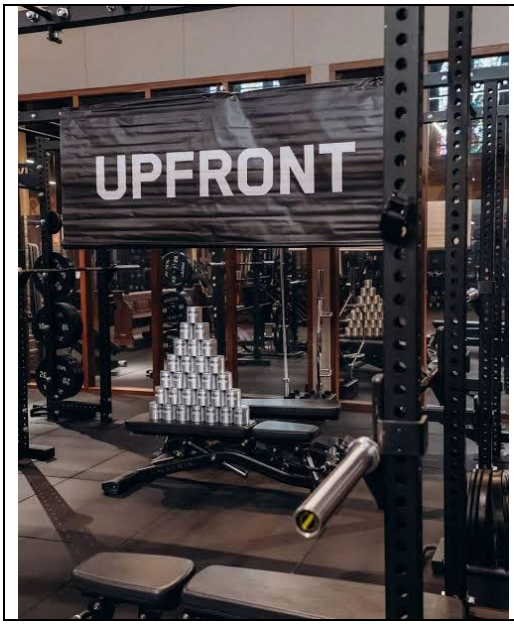
10. Upfront Foodstore

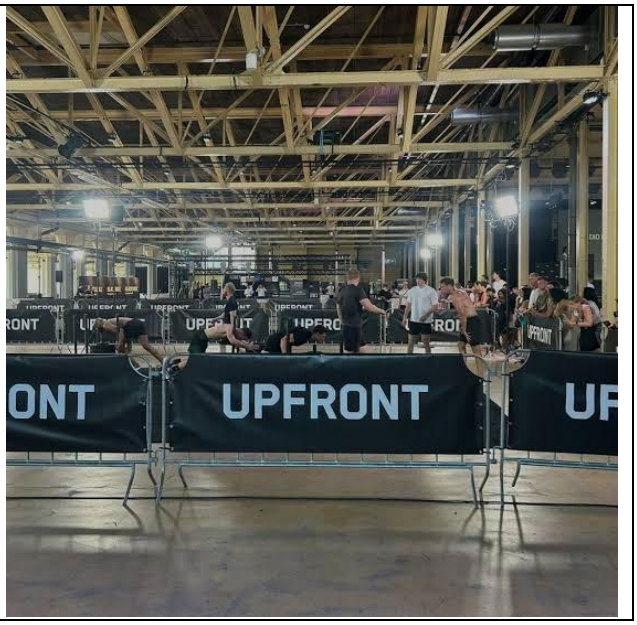


11. Sampling Activity (if observed)



12. Promotion billboards





13. Presence in exhibitions



14. Product Eye-Level Strategy



15. Vegen Highlight Label

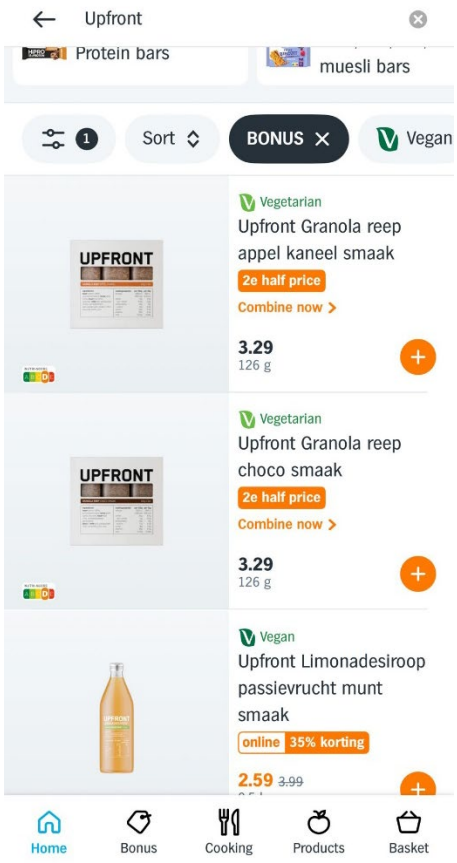


16. Sponsoring sporting events such as marathons





17. Retailer App In-Store Promotion



18. Seasonal Promotional Packaging

Upfront uses limited-edition seasonal packaging variants (e.g. holiday editions) to attract attention on-shelf and drive impulse purchases. The distinct packaging design differentiates the product visually from standard shelf competitors during key retail periods. This is a physical in-store marketing tool observed at Albert Heijn locations.

19. Product Placement in University/Sports Facility Vending Machines

Upfront Protein Bars are available in vending machines located in sports and fitness facilities, including campus environments. Vending machine placement targets consumers at high-intent moments directly after physical activity or during study breaks increasing purchase probability through proximity and convenience (NielsenIQ, 2023).

20. Word-of-Mouth via Community Events and Brand Activations

Beyond formal advertising, Upfront generates brand awareness through informal community activations — including brand ambassador programmes at educational institutions and participation in fitness-related community events. This peer-to-peer communication channel builds organic credibility within the target group of students and health-conscious young adults (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

1.5.3 In-Depth Analysis of One Marketing Example

Example Selected: Shelf-Level Price Promotion in Albert Heijn

Image:



Location:

Albert Heijn supermarket – protein snack section

Target Audience:

Health-conscious supermarket shoppers, including students and young adults.

Marketing Tactic Used:

Limited-time price reduction (price tag highlighted in red).

Why It Stands Out:

Color contrast (red discount tag)
Price anchoring effect
Placed directly below the product at eye-level

Strategic Evaluation

This tactic uses **price anchoring and urgency**, two common retail nudging techniques. According to behavioral economics, visual cues such as color and contrast increase attention and trigger heuristic decision-making (Kahneman, 2011).

For price-sensitive students, temporary discounts reduce financial hesitation and increase trial probability.

Effectiveness Score: 8/10

The color and placement capture attention effectively.

Purchase Influence Score: 7/10

Discounts increase trial, but brand loyalty may still depend on taste and perceived quality.

Overall Impact Score: 7.5/10

Academic Evaluation of Portfolio Findings

The portfolio analysis shows that Upfront's marketing:

- Relies strongly on digital lifestyle communication
- Uses moderate in-store promotional intensity
- Competes visually within a crowded protein category
- Has room for stronger offline activation

While online communication supports transparency and lifestyle positioning, offline presence appears primarily price-driven rather than experience-driven.

This gap presents strategic opportunities for a stronger 360º marketing integration in later chapters.

1.6 Market Trend: Growth of Protein-Based Snacks

In recent years, the market for protein-based food products has grown significantly. Consumers increasingly seek foods that combine convenience with perceived health benefits, such as higher protein content, lower sugar levels, and functional nutritional value. As a result, protein snacks including protein bars have become a rapidly expanding segment within the global snack market.

According to (Euromonitor International, 2025), demand for high-protein snacks has increased due to growing consumer interest in healthier lifestyles and functional nutrition. Protein products are no longer consumed exclusively by athletes but have increasingly entered mainstream food consumption patterns.

Research also shows that protein bars are commonly purchased by **young adults, fitness enthusiasts, and consumers interested in healthier snack alternatives**. These consumers often seek snacks that provide sustained energy, convenience, and nutritional value compared to traditional sweets or chocolate bars (Mintel, 2024).

In the Netherlands, the growing popularity of fitness culture, healthier eating habits, and on-the-go consumption has further contributed to the expansion of the protein snack market. Protein bars are frequently positioned as practical snacks that can be consumed between meals, during work or study, or after physical activity.

Understanding these consumer trends is important when developing a marketing strategy for Upfront protein bars. By identifying the motivations behind protein snack consumption such as convenience, perceived health benefits, and lifestyle alignment marketers can better position the product and communicate its value to relevant consumer segments.

2.1 Benchmark (Competitor Analysis)

2.1.1 Identification of Key Competitors

To understand the competitive environment of the Upfront Protein Bar, a benchmark analysis was conducted with comparable products available in Dutch supermarkets and online retail platforms. Competitors were selected based on three criteria: similarity in product category (protein snack bars), comparable target audiences (health-conscious consumers and active individuals), and similar distribution channels within the Dutch FMCG market.

The following brands were selected for the benchmark analysis.

Barebells Protein Bar

Barebells is one of the most widely distributed protein bar brands in Europe and is commonly available in Dutch supermarkets and fitness-related retail environments. The brand emphasizes indulgent taste while maintaining high protein content, positioning itself as a functional snack for active consumers and gym users (Barebells, 2026).

Fulfil Vitamin & Protein Bar

Fulfil differentiates itself by combining protein content with additional vitamins. The brand markets itself as a nutritionally enhanced snack suitable for consumers seeking convenient functional nutrition (Fulfil Nutrition, 2026).

Grenade Carb Killa Protein Bar

Grenade Carb Killa bars are strongly associated with sports nutrition and bodybuilding culture. The brand focuses on high protein intake, low sugar levels, and performance-oriented nutrition, targeting fitness enthusiasts and athletes (Grenade, 2026).

Eat Natural Protein Bar

Eat Natural protein bars position themselves as a more natural snack option by highlighting simple ingredients and a less processed image. This appeals to consumers interested in healthier and more natural food products (Eat Natural, 2026).

Albert Heijn High Protein Bar

The Albert Heijn High Protein Bar serves as an important price competitor in the Dutch market. Private-label products often compete on price and accessibility, which can influence consumer purchase decisions in supermarket environments (Albert Heijn, 2026).

Including these competitors provides a realistic representation of the protein bar category in the Netherlands.

2.1.2 Competitor Benchmark Comparison

To compare the selected brands, several relevant factors were analyzed, including price, nutritional characteristics, product variety, distribution channels, and brand positioning. Benchmarking these variables helps identify similarities and differences within the protein bar category and provides insight into how Upfront may differentiate itself within the market.

Competitor Benchmark Table

Brand	Price per bar	Protein	Flavours	Distribution	Brand Positioning	Strength	Weakness
Upfront Protein Bar	~€2.29	20g	4	Albert Heijn, online	Lifestyle protein snack	Simple positioning	Limited flavour variety
Barebells	~€2.49	20g	10+	Supermarkets, gyms	Fitness lifestyle	Strong taste marketing	Highly competitive segment
Fulfil	~€2.39	20g	8	Supermarkets	Protein + vitamins	Added nutritional value	Less strong brand personality
Grenade Carb Killa	~€2.69	20g	12+	Gyms, online	Hardcore fitness nutrition	Strong fitness identity	Higher price
AH High Protein Bar	~€1.59	15g	3	Albert Heijn	Budget protein snack	Low price	Lower protein & weaker branding
Eat Natural Protein Bar	~€2.19	10g	5	Supermarkets, health stores	Natural / clean ingredients	Simple, wholesome image	Lower protein content; less brand recognition among younger consumers

2.1.3 Analysis of Competitor Strengths and Weaknesses

The benchmark comparison reveals several important patterns within the protein bar market.

Industry Standardization of Protein Content

Most leading brands provide approximately **20 grams of protein per bar**, suggesting that protein content alone does not function as a strong differentiating factor. This confirms that functional nutritional attributes are becoming standardized within the category (Euromonitor International, 2025).

Fitness-Oriented Market Positioning

Several competitors position themselves strongly within fitness culture. Brands such as Grenade and Barebells use gym-related imagery and performance-focused messaging to attract consumers interested in sports nutrition.

High Product Variety

Some competitors offer a wide range of flavors, which can encourage repeat purchases and experimentation among consumers. Barebells and Grenade provide more than ten flavor options, while Upfront currently offers a smaller product range.

Price Competition

Private-label products, such as the Albert Heijn High Protein Bar, compete primarily on price. Research indicates that supermarket private labels increasingly influence price expectations within FMCG categories (NielsenIQ, 2023).

Diverse Brand Strategies

Different brands emphasize different value propositions:

- **Grenade** → performance nutrition
- **Barebells** → indulgent taste
- **Fulfil** → functional nutrition with added vitamins
- **Eat Natural** → natural ingredients and simple recipes

These strategies demonstrate the diversity within the protein bar category and highlight opportunities for differentiation.

2.1.4 Competitive Positioning and Market Gap

Based on the benchmark analysis, Upfront appears to occupy a slightly different position within the protein bar market. While many competitors focus heavily on athletic performance or indulgent taste, Upfront emphasizes a simpler and more accessible lifestyle-oriented approach.

This positioning creates potential opportunities to target consumers who seek convenient protein snacks but who do not necessarily identify with gym culture. In particular, students and young consumers who require quick energy during studying, gaming, or everyday activities may represent a promising segment.

Developing a stronger focus on everyday functionality rather than extreme sports performance may allow Upfront to differentiate itself in the competitive protein bar market.

2.2 Supplemented USPs & UBRs (Validated with Benchmark)

Following the competitor analysis, the previously identified Unique Selling Points (USPs) and Unique Buying Reasons (UBRs) were reassessed to determine whether they remain valid in comparison with competing brands.

Benchmarking confirms that differentiation in the protein bar category is rarely achieved through nutritional content alone, as most brands offer similar protein levels. Instead, differentiation is primarily achieved through branding, positioning, and perceived lifestyle relevance.

USP 1 – Accessible Lifestyle Nutrition

The competitor benchmark shows that many protein bar brands strongly emphasize gym culture or performance nutrition. Upfront, however, communicates a more accessible and lifestyle-oriented identity.

UBR

Consumers may therefore perceive the product as a snack that fits everyday activities rather than specialized sports nutrition.

“This snack fits my daily routine without requiring an athletic lifestyle.”

Research shows that younger consumers increasingly seek convenient functional snacks that support daily productivity rather than purely athletic performance (International Food Information Council, 2023).

USP 2 – Balanced Price–Quality Positioning

The benchmark analysis indicates that premium protein bars are typically priced between €2.30 and €2.70. Upfront operates within this price range while maintaining competitive protein levels.

UBR

For price-sensitive consumers such as students, this balance between affordability and nutritional value can influence purchase decisions.

“This product offers good nutritional value for the price.”

Price sensitivity remains a key factor in food purchasing decisions, especially among younger consumers and students (CBS(3), 2024).

USP 3 – Broad Lifestyle Appeal

Many competitors focus specifically on athletes or fitness enthusiasts. Upfront's positioning allows it to appeal to a broader audience, including students and young professionals who need convenient snacks during daily activities.

UBR

The resulting consumer motivation becomes:

"This snack helps me maintain energy and focus during everyday tasks such as studying or working."

Functional snacking has become increasingly common among younger consumers who integrate food products into their daily productivity routines (Euromonitor International, 2025).

2.3 Marketing Goals and KPIs

Marketing objectives are essential for evaluating the effectiveness of a marketing strategy. By establishing clear goals and measurable indicators, companies can assess whether their marketing activities are successful and whether they contribute to the overall business objectives. According to the SMART framework, marketing goals should be **specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound**, allowing companies to track performance and adjust their strategies accordingly (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Based on the competitor analysis and the identified opportunities for Upfront protein bars, the following marketing objective is proposed.

Marketing Goal

The main objective of the marketing strategy is to **increase awareness and online engagement for Upfront protein bars among young consumers in the Netherlands**.

A specific SMART goal can be formulated as follows:

Increase online sales of Upfront protein bars by **20% within six months** through targeted digital marketing campaigns, influencer collaborations, and improved social media engagement.

This objective aligns with the brand's current positioning as a convenient and functional snack product and focuses on strengthening the product's visibility among younger consumers who frequently engage with digital platforms.

Key Performance Indicators (KPIs)

To measure the success of the marketing strategy, several **key performance indicators (KPIs)** will be used. KPIs allow marketers to track progress and evaluate whether marketing actions are achieving the desired results.

The KPIs can be grouped into **three categories: sales metrics, marketing performance metrics, and customer metrics**, which are commonly used to evaluate marketing effectiveness.

KPI Category	KPI	Target
Sales Metrics	Online sales growth	Increase monthly online sales by 20% within 6 months
Sales Metrics	Conversion rate	Increase website conversion rate from 2% to 3%
Marketing Metrics	Click-through rate (CTR)	Increase CTR on digital ads from 1.2% to 2%
Marketing Metrics	Social media engagement	Achieve an average engagement rate of 5% on influencer posts
Marketing Metrics	Website traffic	Increase monthly website visitors from campaign sources by 30%
Customer Metrics	Repeat purchase rate	Increase repeat purchase rate from 30% to 40%
Customer Metrics	Customer acquisition cost (CAC)	Reduce CAC through more targeted digital campaigns

These indicators provide measurable benchmarks that allow the company to monitor the effectiveness of the campaign. If the KPIs improve during the campaign period, it indicates that the marketing strategy is successfully influencing consumer awareness, engagement, and purchasing behaviour.

2.4 Sales Funnel (AIDA Model)

A sales funnel is a marketing model that illustrates the process through which potential customers move from initial awareness of a product to eventually making a purchase decision. The funnel demonstrates how the number of potential consumers gradually decreases at each stage of the decision-making process as only a portion of the audience progresses to the next stage. This model allows marketers to identify where consumers drop out of the process and where marketing efforts should be improved (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022) (Chaffey, D., & Ellis-Chadwick, F., 2019).

For the Upfront protein bar, the **AIDA model** is used to describe the customer journey. The AIDA model consists of four stages: **Awareness, Interest, Desire, and Action**, which represent the psychological steps consumers typically go through before making a purchase decision (Kotler, P., & Keller, K. L., 2022).

Awareness

The first stage of the funnel focuses on increasing awareness of the product. At this stage, potential consumers may not yet know the brand or product, so marketing activities aim to increase visibility through channels such as social media advertising, influencer collaborations, and digital marketing campaigns.

Social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok play a particularly important role in reaching younger consumers, as these platforms are widely used among individuals aged 18–30 in the Netherlands (Statista (1), 2024). Digital campaigns on these platforms can therefore reach a large audience and introduce them to the product.

For example, a targeted social media campaign could realistically reach approximately **100,000 potential consumers** through paid advertisements, influencer posts, and organic social media content. At this stage, marketers typically measure performance using indicators such as **impressions, reach, and click-through rates (CTR)**, which are common metrics used to evaluate digital marketing campaigns (Chaffey, D., & Ellis-Chadwick, F., 2019)

Interest

In the interest stage, consumers who have seen the product begin to engage with the brand and explore it further. They may visit the company's website, watch product reviews, or interact with social media content. At this stage, marketing communication should highlight product benefits such as flavour variety, nutritional values, and convenience.

Research shows that only a proportion of consumers who see digital advertisements will proceed to interact with the brand. Average click-through rates for digital display advertisements typically range between **1% and 2%**, depending on the platform and targeting strategy (Kristen McCormick, 2024). Therefore, from an estimated **100,000 individuals reached**, approximately **10–15% may demonstrate interest** by visiting the website, engaging with social media content, or searching for additional information about the product.

KPIs used in this stage may include:

- Website visits
- Social media engagement rates
- Time spent on website pages
- Content interaction metrics

Desire

At the desire stage, consumers develop a stronger interest in purchasing the product and begin to compare it with alternatives. Marketing communication at this stage should emphasize the product's unique selling points, such as ingredient quality, taste, and perceived health benefits.

Consumers increasingly seek snacks that provide both convenience and perceived nutritional value, particularly products that contain higher protein levels compared to traditional snack options (Euromonitor International, 2025). Marketing strategies such as influencer endorsements, user-generated content, and customer reviews can help strengthen purchase intention at this stage.

From the interested consumers, approximately **20–30% may develop purchase intent**, which would represent around **2,000 to 4,500 consumers** who seriously consider buying the product.

KPIs used to measure this stage may include:

- Product page views
- Add-to-cart rates
- Influencer engagement metrics
- Email newsletter sign-ups

Action

The final stage of the funnel occurs when consumers decide to purchase the product. This can take place either online or in physical retail stores such as supermarkets where Upfront protein bars are available.

E-commerce conversion rates for consumer products typically range between **2% and 3%**, meaning that only a small percentage of visitors ultimately complete a purchase (Statista (2), 2024). Based on this benchmark, it is realistic to estimate that approximately **2–3% of the initial campaign audience** could convert into buyers.

KPIs used to evaluate performance at this stage include:

- Conversion rate
- Number of units sold
- Online sales revenue
- Repeat purchase rate

Monitoring these indicators allows marketers to determine whether marketing campaigns successfully guide consumers through the funnel and encourage product purchases.

Funnel Summary (Estimated)

Stage	Estimated Consumers
Awareness	100,000 consumers reached
Interest	10,000 – 15,000 consumers
Desire	2,000 – 4,500 potential buyers
Action	2,000 – 3,000 purchases

These figures represent realistic estimates based on commonly observed digital marketing conversion rates and are used to illustrate how potential consumers may progress through the sales funnel.

3.0 Practical marketing strategy

Based on the analysis in Chapter 1 and 2, including the target group, market trends, and competitive environment, this chapter focuses on translating these insights into a practical marketing strategy. The goal is to improve the current positioning of Upfront protein bars by using a customer-focused and data-driven approach.

3.1 Enrich Marketing Mix (4Ps → SIVA)

To better align the marketing strategy with customer needs, the traditional 4Ps model is translated into the SIVA model, which focuses more on the customer perspective instead of the product itself.

- **Solution (Product → Solution)**
  Upfront protein bars provide a convenient and healthy snack solution for students and young active consumers who need quick energy and improved focus during study or sports activities. The product solves the need for a nutritious, high-protein snack that supports performance and lifestyle.
- **Information (Price → Information)**
  Instead of focusing only on price, Upfront communicates clear information about nutritional value, protein content, and health benefits. Consumers today are more interested in transparency and understanding what they consume, especially in fitness-related products.
- **Value (Promotion → Value)**
  The value of Upfront is not only in its price but in the benefits it delivers, such as energy, convenience, and health support. Compared to traditional snacks, protein bars provide functional value, making them more attractive for health-conscious consumers.
- **Access (Place → Access)**
  Upfront products are available in supermarkets like Albert Heijn and online platforms, allowing customers to purchase easily anytime and anywhere. The focus is on accessibility and convenience rather than only distribution channels.

3.2 External Analysis

◆ Opportunities

O1. Increasing demand for healthy and protein-based products

There is a strong global trend toward health-conscious consumption, with more consumers actively choosing high-protein and functional foods. The demand for protein snacks is growing due to increasing awareness of nutrition, fitness, and healthy lifestyles (Statista (3), 2024) (McKinsey & Company., 2025).

Opportunity:
The growing demand for health-oriented and protein-rich snacks presents a market entry opportunity for brands positioned around functional nutrition and convenience (Statista (3), 2024; McKinsey & Company., 2025).

O2. Growth of fitness and active lifestyle among young consumers

In the Netherlands, younger consumers are increasingly engaged in sports and health-related activities. Data from CBS and RIVM shows a growing focus on physical activity and healthy eating behavior (CBS (4), 2023) (RVIM, 2023).

Opportunity:
The rising engagement of Dutch youth in fitness and sports activities creates an opportunity for protein snack brands to align with performance and daily energy narratives within this growing active lifestyle segment (CBS (4), 2023; RVIM, 2023).

O3. Influence of digital and social media marketing

Digital platforms such as TikTok and Instagram play a major role in shaping consumer behavior, especially among younger audiences. Social media influences product discovery, brand awareness, and purchase decisions (Think with Google, 2026) (NielsenIQ, 2023).

Opportunity:
The increasing role of digital platforms — particularly TikTok and Instagram — in shaping food purchase decisions among 18–30-year-olds represents an opportunity for protein brands to achieve high-reach awareness at a relatively low cost per impression (Think with Google, 2026; NielsenIQ, 2023).

O4. Location-based consumption behavior

Consumers are more likely to purchase snacks that are easily accessible in their daily environments, such as universities and gyms (CBS(3), 2024) (NielsenIQ, 2023).

Opportunity:
Consumer research confirms that snack purchases are strongly influenced by product proximity to daily environments such as universities and fitness centres, meaning brands distributed in these locations benefit from higher impulse purchase rates among the core target group (CBS(3), 2024; NielsenIQ, 2023).

Threats

T1. Increasing regulation on food and sugar content

European regulations on food labeling and nutritional standards are becoming stricter, especially regarding sugar and processed foods (European Parliament & Council, 2011) (RVIM, 2023).

Threat:
If protein bars are perceived as unhealthy or high in sugar, this may negatively affect consumer perception and sales.

T2. Market saturation of protein snack brands

The protein snack market is becoming highly competitive, with many brands offering similar products. Health and wellness trends have attracted many competitors into the market (Euromonitor International, 2025) (Statista (3), 2024).

Threat:
Upfront may face challenges in differentiating itself and gaining market share.

T3. Consumer skepticism toward processed products

Consumers are becoming more critical of processed food products and are increasingly looking for natural and clean-label alternatives (NielsenIQ, 2023) (McKinsey & Company., 2025).

Threat:
If protein bars are perceived as artificial or overly processed, consumers may switch to alternative snacks.

3.3 Cross Media Plan

Strategy Plan

To better reach the target group (students and active young consumers), the strategy is extended by **placing the product and promotions directly in environments where this audience is present**, such as universities and gyms.

Research shows that proximity and availability strongly influence food choices, especially for convenience products (CBS (4), 2023) (NielsenIQ, 2023). Additionally, fitness environments increase the likelihood of purchasing protein-related products (McKinsey & Company., 2025).

This makes universities and gyms high-impact touchpoints.

The strategy follows a 360° marketing approach by integrating both online and offline channels. Social media platforms such as TikTok and Instagram create awareness and engagement, while physical availability in gyms, universities, and retail stores drives conversion. These channels are interconnected, ensuring consistent brand communication across all touchpoints.

New Channel 1: University Activation

Placement

- University cafeterias
- Vending machines
- Campus shops

Why this works

Students often choose **quick and convenient snacks between lectures**, and availability on campus increases purchase probability (CBS (4), 2023).

Also, impulse buying is higher in familiar environments (NielsenIQ, 2023)

Promotion Ideas

- “Study Boost Bar” campaign

- Discount during exam periods
- Free samples on campus

Goal: Awareness + Conversion
KPI: Sales per location, trial rate

New Channel 2: Gym & Fitness Partnerships

Placement

- Gym reception / vending machines
- Fitness centers (e.g., Basic-Fit style concept)

Why this works

Protein consumption is strongly linked to **fitness behavior and muscle recovery needs** (RVIM, 2023) (McKinsey & Company., 2025).

Consumers in gyms are already **highly motivated to buy protein products**, which increases conversion.

This is a **high-intent environment**

Promotion Ideas

- “Post-Workout Recovery Bar”
- Influencer trainers promoting the product
- Bundle offers (bar + drink)

Goal: Conversion + Loyalty

KPI: Repeat purchases, sales volume

Each KPI is directly linked to a specific stage of the customer journey, allowing performance measurement at every step of the funnel.

Integration with Existing Channels

Channel	KPI	Expected Result
TikTok	Impressions	200K–400K reach
Instagram	Engagement rate	5–10% interaction
Universities	Trial rate	High sampling conversion
Gyms	Repeat purchase	Loyalty building
In-store	Sales volume	Direct purchase



This creates a **full 360° strategy (online + offline)**

The selected KPIs are directly linked to the customer journey stages, ensuring that each marketing activity can be measured effectively in terms of awareness, engagement, and conversion.

3.4 Budget Overview

The total estimated budget for the campaign is **€6,500**, allocated across digital and offline channels.

To estimate the expected return, conversion assumptions are based on industry benchmarks for FMCG and digital campaigns (CBS(3), 2024) (NielsenIQ, 2023).

- Estimated reach: **300,000 users**
- Expected conversion rate: **2–4%**
- Estimated buyers: **6,000 – 12,000 consumers**

Assuming an average price of **€2.50 per protein bar**, the expected revenue is:

€15,000 – €30,000

This results in a positive return on marketing investment (ROMI), indicating that the campaign is financially viable.

Channel	Budget	Expected Result
TikTok Ads	€2,000	High reach
Instagram Ads	€1,000	Engagement
Posters	€1,500	Awareness
University activation	€1,200	Trial + sales
Gym partnerships	€800	High conversion

Total: €6,500

This strategy is effective because it targets consumers in their daily environments while reinforcing the message through digital channels. This increases both exposure frequency and purchase likelihood.

3.5 Focus

Although the protein bar market is growing, Upfront is still relatively unknown compared to competitors (Euromonitor International, 2025). Therefore, creating awareness is the most critical first step before driving conversions.

Additionally, the target group (students and gym users) is highly influenced by visibility, social media, and peer recommendations (NielsenIQ, 2023).

For this reason, the strategy prioritizes:

1. Awareness (social media & outdoor)
2. Engagement (content & influencers)

3. Conversion (universities, gyms, retail)

This phased approach aligns with the customer journey and increases the effectiveness of the campaign.

A limitation of this strategy is that the estimated conversion rates are based on general industry benchmarks rather than company-specific data. Future research could improve accuracy by using real sales data from Upfront.

4.0 Conclusion

This report developed a 360° marketing strategy for Upfront protein bars, focusing on students and active young consumers. Based on market trends such as increasing demand for protein products and convenience foods, a clear opportunity was identified to improve brand visibility and accessibility.

The proposed strategy combines online channels such as TikTok and Instagram with offline presence in universities and gyms. This integrated approach ensures that the target group is reached at multiple touchpoints during their daily routine.

By linking marketing activities to clear KPIs, the strategy allows for measurable results in awareness, engagement, and sales. Overall, this approach strengthens the competitive position of Upfront in the growing protein snack market.

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